

El Renacimiento de Harlem

Grades 5–8 • Spanish Language Arts

GRADES 5–8

45 MINUTES

SPANISH LANGUAGE ARTS

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What Students Will Understand

Students will build Spanish vocabulary related to the Harlem Renaissance — art, music, culture, history, and human rights — while exploring the shared experience of the African diaspora across the Americas. They will practise vocabulary in context, discuss themes of cultural identity and expression in Spanish, and make connections between the Harlem Renaissance and Spanish-speaking Caribbean cultures (Afro-Cuban music, the Negrismo movement in Puerto Rico and Cuba).

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

ACTFL Interpretive	Interpret written and oral language on familiar and some unfamiliar topics with developing comprehension
ACTFL Interpersonal	Participate in conversations on familiar topics using a variety of strategies; express and support opinions
ACTFL Presentational	Present information and ideas on familiar topics with accuracy and detail appropriate to proficiency level

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Differentiated handouts (Green / Yellow / Red) — one per student
- Optional: audio clip of Afro-Cuban jazz (Celia Cruz, Tito Puente) to open the connection between Harlem jazz and Latin music
- Optional: short reading in Spanish about Nicolás Guillén (Cuban poet influenced by the Harlem Renaissance) for Red-level extension

HOOK: LA MÚSICA CONECTA (5 MINUTES)

"Antes de hablar del Renacimiento de Harlem, quiero que escuchen esto." [Play 30 seconds of Afro-Cuban jazz or salsa.] "¿Reconocen algo? Esta música viene de Cuba — pero sus raíces están en el jazz de Harlem. Los músicos afrocubanos y los músicos afroamericanos de Harlem estaban creando algo nuevo al mismo tiempo, inspirados por las mismas tradiciones africanas. Hoy vamos a explorar estas conexiones."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION: VOCABULARIO CLAVE (10 MINUTES)

Introduce and practise the core vocabulary set with visual and contextual support. Use the images on handouts: *la silueta, el renacimiento, la dignidad, la migración, el jazz, la pintura, el poeta / la poeta, la identidad, la libertad, la resistencia, la herencia*. For each word: model pronunciation, ask students to use it in a sentence, then use it in the context of the Harlem Renaissance.

ACTIVITY (25 MINUTES)

Green

Vocabulary matching and fill-in with word bank (all words with English glosses provided). Describe Aaron Douglas's *Song of the Towers* in 3 Spanish sentences using the vocabulary. Answer 3 comprehension questions in Spanish.

Yellow

Vocabulary in context (sentences and short paragraph). Write a 5-sentence description of the Harlem Renaissance in Spanish. Respond in Spanish to: ¿Por qué era importante el Renacimiento de Harlem? Connect to a Spanish-speaking cultural figure or movement.

Red

Read a short paragraph in Spanish about Nicolás Guillén (Cuban Negrismo poet). Analyse: what connections can you find between Guillén's poetry and the Harlem Renaissance? Write a comparative paragraph in Spanish.

Discussion question: ¿Puede el arte cambiar la sociedad?

CLOSING (5 MINUTES)

"El Renacimiento de Harlem no fue sólo un movimiento americano — fue parte de un despertar cultural global de la diáspora africana. En Cuba, en Puerto Rico, en Brasil — artistas y poetas estaban haciendo lo mismo: afirmando la belleza y la dignidad de la cultura africana. Estas conversaciones cruzaron fronteras y océanos."

Mini Museum Connection

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit. **Option 2 — Virtual Visit:** minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

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VOCABULARIO PRINCIPAL — TEACHER REFERENCE

Spanish	English	Example sentence
el renacimiento	the renaissance / rebirth	El Renacimiento de Harlem fue un movimiento cultural.
la silueta	the silhouette	Aaron Douglas pintaba siluetas sin rasgos individuales.
la dignidad	dignity	Los artistas afirmaban la dignidad de la vida negra.
la migración	migration	La Gran Migración transformó las ciudades del norte.
la herencia	heritage / inheritance	El jazz celebraba la herencia africana.
la identidad	identity	Los poetas exploraban su identidad cultural.
la resistencia	resistance	El arte fue una forma de resistencia.
la libertad	freedom / liberty	La música expresaba el deseo de libertad.
el orgullo	pride	Había un nuevo orgullo en la cultura negra.
afrocubano/a	Afro-Cuban	La música afrocubana tenía raíces africanas similares.

CARIBBEAN CONNECTION — TEACHER NOTES

Negrismo (Cuba/Puerto Rico, 1920s–30s): A literary movement parallel to the Harlem Renaissance, led by poets like Nicolás Guillén (Cuba) and Luis Palés Matos (Puerto Rico). Both movements celebrated African heritage, used African-influenced rhythms in poetry, and asserted the dignity of Afro-Caribbean identity. Guillén and Langston Hughes knew each other and corresponded — the movements were genuinely interconnected.

Afro-Cuban Music: Rooted in the same African traditions as jazz (call-and-response, polyrhythm, improvisation), Afro-Cuban music developed simultaneously with Harlem jazz. By the 1940s, musicians like Dizzy Gillespie were fusing both traditions into what became known as Afro-Cuban jazz or Cubop.

CROSS-CURRICULAR CONNECTIONS

- **Social Studies:** The African diaspora connects the Harlem Renaissance to Caribbean, Central American, and South American cultural movements — a global context for what students might think of as a "local" American story
- **Music:** The jazz/salsa/cumbia connection can be traced musically — same African rhythmic roots, different cultural expressions
- **Religion:** *La dignidad humana* is a key term in Catholic Social Teaching in Spanish — the vocabulary connects directly to CST Principle 1